

Pine Creek High School Marching Band

2026 Production: Continuum — Field Prop Operations Guide

Simplified Volunteer Handbook & Step-by-Step Competition Day Procedures

☀️ CORE PROGRAM PHILOSOPHY:

The focus is always on the kids' performance, not the props. Props exist strictly to support and enhance the visual spectacle of the students' musicianship and marching. If conditions become hazardous or timing breaks down, props are abandoned or held back without hesitation. **Nothing we do on the prop crew will ever compromise a student's safety or their competitive show.**

1. Wind Safety Plan & Mandatory NO-GO Contingencies

Because Pine Creek High School operates in the high-altitude, wind-prone environment of Colorado Springs (6,500 ft ASL) and competes in open stadium venues, wind safety controls must be understood by every parent and volunteer before touching a prop.

🔴 ABSOLUTE WIND NO-GO THRESHOLD (>20 MPH)

HARD RULE: If sustained winds exceed 20 mph OR gusts are forecasted/reported at 25–30 mph, PROPS DO NOT LEAVE THE TRUCK/TRAILER.

Last season confirmed that props in >20 mph winds create unacceptable safety risks for students and handlers. When this threshold is met, the Prop Lead makes an immediate **NO-GO** call. Props remain securely locked in the equipment trailer or behind stadium bleachers. **The band performs a clean visual show without props.** There is no middle ground, and no emergency lay-flat abort on the field is permitted—if high winds are even possible, props stay off the turf.

Wind Regime	Wind Velocity	Operational Action & Ballasting	Decision Status
🟡 Tier 0: Calm	0 – 8 mph	Nominal calm conditions. 0 ballast needed on duck blinds / backdrops. Normal transit and entry.	GO (Dry)
🟢 Tier 1: Normal	8 – 12 mph	Standard deployment. Ground rail ballast (Duck Blinds: 1–2 bags; Backdrops: 4 bags [2/wing post]; Stages: wheel locks).	GO (Normal)
🟡 Tier 2: Advisory	12 – 18 mph	Elevated vigilance. Full ballast deployed (Duck Blinds: 3 bags [2 ground + 1 hanging]; Backdrops: 6 bags [3/wing post]). Maintain two-hand grip.	GO (With Ballast)
🟠 Tier 3: High-Wind	18 – 22 mph	Maximum safe limit. Heavy ballast (Duck Blinds: 4 bags [2 ground + 2 hanging]; Backdrops: 9 bags [6 wing + 3 rear rail]). Extra handlers.	CAUTION (Max Limit)
🔴 Tier 4: Abort	> 20 mph sust. or > 25 mph gusts	ABSOLUTE NO-GO. Props remain in trailer / truck. Field props will not be fielded. Prop Lead notifies Directors and CBA judge.	NO-GO (Hold in Truck)

Why There Is No Emergency Lay-Flat Plan in This Handout

Previous operational drafts included field procedures for laying props flat on the turf during sudden gusts. For volunteer safety and competition clarity, **that procedure has been retired.** If 25–30 mph gusts are even remotely possible, the props will never be staged or moved onto the field.

2. Competition Day Schedule & Contact Information

Volunteers: Fill in the times and contacts below during morning check-in. Keep this sheet accessible in your pocket or clipboard throughout competition day.

Logistical Milestone	Scheduled Time	Specific Location / Gate Instructions
Competition & Venue	_____	Stadium: _____
Prop Lead of the Day	Name: _____	Cell Phone: (____) ____ - _____
Staging Area Location	Location / Area: _____	_____
Prop Staging Time	____ : ____ AM / PM	Staged once; props return here between Prelims & Finals
Equipment Truck Arrival	____ : ____ AM / PM	Parking Lot / Bay: _____
Volunteer Crew Call Time	____ : ____ AM / PM	Check-in at Equipment Trailer
Truck Unload & Assembly	____ : ____ AM / PM	Equipment Trailer Lot / Staging Lot
Band Warm-up Departure	____ : ____ AM / PM	Escort carts to Warm-up Zone / Gate
Prelims Prop Gate Queue	____ : ____ AM / PM	Rear Entrance Gate (Back Sideline)
Prelims Performance	____ : ____ AM / PM	T&P Clock Starts on Judge's Signal
Prelims Return to Staging	Immediate post-prelims	Return props to Staging Area between runs
Finals Gate Queue (if adv.)	____ : ____ AM / PM	Rear Entrance Gate
Finals Performance	____ : ____ AM / PM	Evening Performance Slot
Final Packdown & Depart	____ : ____ AM / PM	Trailer locked & ready for transit

3. Critical CBA Rules for Parent Volunteers

The Colorado Bandmasters Association (CBA) strictly enforces prop and adult volunteer regulations. **Penalties directly deduct points from the students' score.** Adhere strictly to the following:

⚠ Rule 9.07 — Field Passes

Maximum 25 wristbands per band. Every parent stepping past the gate must wear the official CBA wristband on their wrist (not in pocket or on badge). Prelims and Finals use different colors.

⚠ Rule 5.02 — Rear Entrance Mandate

Props must enter from the back sideline or rear end zone. Never wheel props across the front boundary line (reserved strictly for pit/percussion equipment). Handlers transit perimeter tracks.

⚠ Rule 4.03 & 5.06 — 3:15 Setup Window

The introductory announcement begins 3 minutes 15 seconds after judge's entry signal. **ALL adults must be completely clear of the field before the announcement ends.** Target all adults off turf by **2:45**.

⚠ Rule 4.03 — In-Show Turf Prohibition

Parents are strictly forbidden from touching the field during the performance. 0.2-point penalty per occurrence. Once you exit, remain behind the front sideline or rear perimeter track.

⚠ Rule 8.05 — 2:00 Egress Clock

Timing clock begins on final chord. All equipment and personnel must clear field boundaries within 2 minutes. Once past the gate/tunnel threshold, carts pause in the exit chute to load the duck blinds.

⚠ Rule 8.05 — Double-Bagged Sandbags

All ballast sandbags must be heavy-duty and double-bagged with intact plastic inner liners. Leaking sand on synthetic turf results in severe facility fines and competition penalties.

4. 2026 Continuum Prop Fleet Summary

The 2026 visual design for **Continuum** incorporates three prop families totaling 30 field elements:

Prop Category	Quantity	Transport Unit	Field Placement	Crew Allocation
Duck Blinds (Sideline Screens)	16 screens (8 per side)	2 Rolling Carts (8 screens/cart)	Front Sideline (Side 1: 20–41 yd; Side 2: 59–80 yd)	2 Adult Pushers, 2 Student Unloaders, 16 Student Receivers
Rolling Backdrops	10 backdrops	10 Rolling Carts (1 cart/prop)	Backfield / Back Hash (Spanned across 30–70 yds)	10–20 Parent Volunteers (1–2 pushers per backdrop)
Performance Stages	4 stages	4 Mobile Platforms (Integrated casters)	Midfield / Side Stages (Exact drill marks per show)	8 Parent Volunteers (2 pushers per stage platform)

5. Individual Job Descriptions & Step-by-Step Instructions

Find your assigned job card on the following pages. Each job is formatted as an independent, single-page operations sheet that can be printed and carried during competition day.

The field prop operation is organized into four primary divisions:

- Job Group A: Duck Blind Operations (Pages 4–7):** Divided into four specialized single-page job blocks covering cart pushing, rapid cart offloading, on-field concurrent deployment, and post-show egress.
- Job Group B: Rolling Backdrop Crew (Page 8):** Dedicated operations sheet for the 10 parent pushers handling backfield rolling backdrops (1 through 10).
- Job Group C: Performance Stage Crew (Page 9):** Dedicated operations sheet for the 4 midfield mobile platform handler teams.
- Job Group D: Prop Lead & Field Safety Coordinator (Page 9):** Master oversight, weather telemetry monitoring, judge liaison, and timing control.

Follow all instructions in strict sequential order. Adhere to all safety warnings and CBA competition boundaries.

Job Group A: Duck Blind Crew (16 Sideline Screens on 2 Dedicated Carts)

Job A.1: Adult Duck Blind Cart Pusher

Crew: 2 Adult Volunteers (1 per Cart: Side 1 or Side 2)

You will be in charge of one of two carts for transporting the duck blinds to and from the field. You will be in charge of ensuring it is loaded properly with 8 duck blinds and the correct amount of ballast, ensuring that it gets to the field on time, and removing the ballast from the field after the show. You will have student helpers to assist on field.

DAY-OF CART ASSIGNMENT:

Side: Staging Location:

☐ Side 1 (Right) Back _____ Yard Line

☐ Side 2 (Left)

DUCK BLIND BALLAST SCHEDULE:

Tier	Wind Regime	Per Blind (15-lb Bags)	Per Cart
	MPH		
0	0–8	0 bags (dry frame)	0 bags
1	8–12	1–2 on ground (15–30 lb)	8–16 bags
2	12–18	2 ground + 1 hang (45 lb)	24 bags
3	18–22	2 ground + 2 hang (60 lb)	32 bags
4	>20	NO-GO (Hold in Trailer)	In Trailer

Complete Event Lifecycle (Truck → Staging → Field → Standby → Exit Chute → Staging/Truck):

- Arrival, Unload & Assembly:** Meet at the equipment trailer at the volunteer crew call time. Assist with unloading the props and pit equipment from the trucks and trailers. Assist with assembly of the props. Note: duck blinds are fully assembled, but the backdrops and stages both require multiple people to perform the assembly work.
- Move to Staging Area:** Move props and carts to the designated staging area at the designated staging time.
- Pre-Show Inspection:** Meet at the Staging Area 45 minutes prior to show time. Conduct a visual inspection of the cart, screen racks, and latches. Confirm sandbag quantity in the hopper matches the Ballast Schedule above (e.g., 8–16 bags for Tier 1; 24 bags for Tier 2; 32 bags for Tier 3). Push cart to the ready area as directed by the Prop Lead. Meet your assigned Student Unloader who will join you following their warm-ups.
- Field Staging A:** When directed by the on-field judge, enter the gates and stage at the prescribed location.
- Field Staging B:** When directed by the on-field judge, move to the defined yard line along the back sideline. **DO NOT CROSS THE SIDELINE MARKERS.** Doing so will immediately invoke an official penalty.
- Field Ingress & Directional Delivery:** When the CBA judge signals entry permission, push the cart forward toward the front sideline with your Student Unloader. When you reach the front sideline, turn and walk along the front sideline, pausing 6–8 seconds at each 2-yard mark while the unloader deposits one folded screen and sandbags to the pre-set student receiver.
- In-Show Standby at Sideline Boundary:** Once the 8th screen is delivered, immediately push the empty cart across the front boundary into the front staging area. **You must be completely off the turf before the 2:15 mark.** Park the cart ready for post-show egress. **Stay with your cart at the boundary for the entire performance.** Never step onto the turf during the show (Rule 4.03 penalty).
- Post-Show Ballast Sweep:** Once the show is completed, re-enter the front sideline at the far screen and move along the line of ballast bags you previously deposited. Scoop ballast bags placed on the turf by students directly into the cart hopper as you advance without doubling back. A student will be assigned to assist you in getting this done timely.
- Exit Chute Cart Loading:** We will be pausing at the exit chute with the carts to load the blinds. **DO NOT STOP FOR ANY LONGER THAN NECESSARY TO QUICKLY LOAD THE BLINDS.**
- Return to Staging Area or Truck:** Return the carts to the staging area (between Prelims and Finals), or directly to the trailer/truck if after Finals.
- Final Performance Teardown & Loading:** At the end of the final performance, tear down all equipment and assist with loading the truck and trailer.

Side 1 is on the right when standing on the backfield and facing the front stands.

Job Group A: Duck Blind Crew (Continued)**Job A.2: Student Duck Blind Cart Unloader**

Crew: 2 Student Performers / Crew (1 per Cart: Side 1 or Side 2)

Cart Operations & Rapid Offloading

Student Instructions: You accompany the Adult Cart Pusher from the rear gate to the front sideline, rapidly offload the 8 screens and assigned ballast bags to your fellow student performers, and clear the turf to take your opening drill position.

1. Rear Gate Rendezvous:

- Meet your assigned Adult Cart Pusher at the rear stadium entrance gate as directed by your section leader.
- Work with your section leader to get your instrument to your starting location on the field. The cart does not have instrument storage capabilities.
- Confirm with the Adult Cart Pusher the number of ballast bags to unload with each duck blind. Note this value will change depending on the wind conditions that day.

2. Perimeter Track Transit:

- Remain with the cart during entry and backfield staging as directed.

3. Field Entrance:

- When given the go-ahead by the on-field judge, move quickly with the cart straight forward to the front sideline.

4. Screen & Ballast Deposition (6-Second Drop Cadence):

- Once you reach the front sideline, walk along the sideline with the cart. As it rolls past each marked 2-yard line (screens 1 through 8):
 - Slide one folded screen off the cart rack.
 - Set the folded screen flat on the turf near the final location for that screen. Additional student helpers will be there to set the blind up.
 - Set the correct amount of ballast bags with each duck blind.
- Maintain a crisp, rapid pace: complete each handoff within **6 seconds** so the cart maintains forward momentum without stalling.
 - Repeat down the entire 8-screen line.

5. Field Clearance to Opening Show Drill Set:

- Once the 8th screen and final sandbags are deposited, briskly transition to your assigned opening performance location. You are now cleared for the show!

Job Group A: Duck Blind Crew (Continued)**Job A.3: Student Screen Deployment & Ballasting****Crew: 16 Student Performers (8 on Side 1, 8 on Side 2)****On-Field Screen Deployment & Rigidity**

Student Instructions: *You are responsible for receiving, unfolding, latching, and ballasting the 16 duck blind sideline screens. You will be assigned one or more duck blinds to be your responsibility.*

1. Pre-Show Field Positioning:

- March onto the field with the band during entry and proceed to your assigned front sideline coordinate. Coordinate with your section leader for instrument placement while you perform your duties.
- Stand at attention facing the backfield awaiting the arrival of your transport cart.

2. Receiving Screen & Ballast:

- As your transport cart arrives at your mark:
 - Receive 1 folded screen and ballast bags from the Student Unloader. Note that the ballast bag quantity will change based on wind conditions.
 - Place the folded screen standing vertically, display face toward the front audience.

3. Concurrent Unfolding & Lockup (15 Seconds):

- As soon as the screen is on the turf, all 8 performers on your side deploy simultaneously:
 - Swing the rear triangular support frame outward perpendicular to the front display panel.
 - Seat the snap clips (I) firmly into Rail 3 until fully engaged with an audible snap.
 - Adjust the position from center field outwards to ensure all blinds are aligned continuously into one front visual wall.

4. Ballast Installation:

- Place the ballast provided onto the duck blind in this order:
 - Place up to 2 bags across the rear ground rail.
 - Place up to 2 bags hanging from the top rail using the attached clips.

5. Rigidity Check & Show Posture:

- Give the frame a firm tap to confirm the snap clips and latches are fully seated and the screen is 100% rigid.
- Step back into your opening visual set posture before the introductory announcement ends.

Job Group A: Duck Blind Crew (Continued)**Job A.4: Student Screen Teardown & Egress**

Crew: 16 Student Performers (8 on Side 1, 8 on Side 2)

Post-Show Deballasting & Egress Sprint

Student Instructions: The 2-minute CBA egress clock starts the instant the final note of the show sounds. Disengage, collapse, and move your screens off the field quickly within the 2-minute egress window.

1. Immediate Teardown on Final Show Chord:

- After the show as directed by your section leader:
 - **Safe Ballast Placement:** Lift all sandbags off the rear ground rail and unclip any hanging bags; place them gently onto the synthetic turf next to the rail. **CRITICAL SAFETY MANDATE: NEVER THROW OR DROP SANDBAGS.** Dropping sandbags causes severe seam rupture and leaks sand, resulting in CBA score penalties. Place bags gently on the turf. Leave them in place for the Adult Cart Pusher to scoop during their sweep.
 - **Disengage Latches & Clips:** Disengage inter-screen side latches. Disengage snap clips (I) from Rail 3. Swing the cross arms up into alignment with the rear brace.
 - **Collapse Screen:** Swing the rear triangular brace flat against the front display frame.

2. The 35-Second Egress Sprint:

- Move quickly, hand-carrying the collapsed screens across the front sideline boundary and toward the designated stadium exit gate chute.

3. Replace on Cart:

- Exit the field to the pre-coordinated area to meet the cart rack.
- Replace screens in the transport cart racks (8 screens per cart).
- Rejoin the band.

Job Group B: Rolling Backdrop Crew (10 Backdrops on Dedicated Carts)

Job B.1: Rolling Backdrop Pushers

Crew: 10 to 20 Parent Volunteers (1–2 per Cart)

Backdrop Props #1 through #10

1. **Staging & Inspection (45 min prior):** Locate your assigned backdrop cart (1 through 10) in the staging lot. Verify: (a) graphic banner faces the correct direction; (b) 4 to 6 double-bagged 15-lb sandbags (or up to 9 bags in Tier 3) are securely seated over the two vertical iron pipe posts; (c) swivel casters roll freely; (d) caster foot brake levers are in the unlocked (UP) position.
2. **Gate Queue Order:** Queue on the back sideline track in strict numerical order (1 at front, 10 at rear).
3. **Field Ingress:** When the judge signals, push the cart onto the field following the perimeter lane to your marked backfield yard coordinate. **Safety:** Push using the wooden 2x4 frame uprights or dedicated push handles. **NEVER push directly against the vinyl display face.**
4. **Positioning & Brake Lock:** Align the front edge of the wood base cart precisely with the yard line and hash mark specified on your drill card. **Immediately step on the caster foot brake levers on all four swivel casters to lock wheels.**
5. **Ballast Check:** Confirm the sandbags are resting fully on the plywood deck wings over the iron posts.
6. **Clear Field Before 2:45:** Once the cart is locked, turn and walk briskly off the back sideline into the rear staging area. **Do not linger.** Ensure you are across the boundary before the introductory announcement begins.
7. **Post-Show Egress:** At the final chord of the show, immediately step onto the turf, kick the caster brake levers into the unlocked (UP) position, and push the cart continuously toward the designated stadium exit chute.
8. **Continuous Motion (Rule 8.05): DO NOT STOP in the stadium tunnel or exit chute to talk, rest, or de-ballast.** Keep moving until the cart is fully parked in the equipment trailer lot.

Job Group C: Performance Stage Crew (4 Mobile Platforms, Stages 1 through 4)

Job C.1: Performance Stage Handlers

Crew: 8 Parent Volunteers (2 Handlers per Stage Platform)

Stages #1 through #4

1. **Staging & Safety Inspection:** Inspect your assigned stage platform. Verify decking surface is clean, dry, and non-slip. Confirm wheel lock levers and retractable leveling outriggers operate smoothly.
2. **Ingress & Positioning:** On the entry signal, two handlers push the stage platform from the rear gate to its designated performance mark. Avoid sudden pivoting on turf.
3. **Locking & Rigidity Verification:** Once at the mark, engage all caster wheel locks and extend/tighten stability outriggers until platform is 100% rigid. Give the platform a firm hand-shake to confirm zero wobble before student performers approach.
4. **Field Clearance:** Clear the performance field before the 2:45 mark and stand by at the nearest boundary.
5. **Post-Show Egress:** At the final chord, immediately return to the stage platform, retract outriggers, disengage wheel locks, and push the platform off the field through the exit gate in continuous motion to the trailer lot.

Job Group D: Prop Lead & Field Safety Coordinator

Job D.1: Prop Lead & Field Safety Coordinator

Crew: 1–2 Experienced Prop Directors / Leads

Overall Field Operations & Safety

1. **Weather Monitoring:** Carry a handheld digital anemometer and monitor live airport METAR weather feeds. Issue the **NO-GO** directive if wind speeds exceed 20 mph sustained or gusts reach 25–30 mph.
2. **Judge Liaison & Gate Release:** Coordinate directly with the CBA Timing & Penalty judge at the gate. Signal the prop crew the instant entry permission is granted.
3. **The 2:45 Clearance Call:** Monitor stopwatch. At 2:30, loudly call **“PROPS CLEAR!”** down the sideline and confirm all 25 adult volunteers are across the boundary line before the 3:15 announcement begins.
4. **Exit Chute Traffic Management:** Stand at the stadium exit gate during post-show egress to prevent cart bottlenecks and ensure continuous flow into the trailer parking lot.

6. Post-Show Deballasting & Trailer Packdown

All teardown and packdown procedures occur **exclusively in the equipment trailer parking lot** after clearing the stadium exit gate:

1. **Deballasting Safety:** Remove sandbags from backdrop retention posts and duck blind carts. Place bags gently into the designated heavy-duty storage totes inside the equipment trailer. **Never drop or throw sandbags** (protects seams and plastic liners).
2. **Screen Packing:** Stack collapsed sideline screens flat in the transport cart racks (8 screens per cart, hinges alternating to maintain coplanar nesting ≤ 2.0 inches). Secure retaining gate latches with 3D-printed locking pins.
3. **Trailer Loading:** Roll backdrops and carts into the trailer in reverse numerical order. Set wheel brakes, engage wheel chocks, and secure ratcheting cargo straps across each frame before transit.
4. **All-Clear Check:** Inspect the staging lot for personal belongings, water bottles, and tools. Verify all 25 volunteer wristbands are accounted for.

Competition Day Volunteer Quick Reference Checklist

Before Entering Gate:

- Official CBA wristband secured to wrist (Rule 9.07)
- Arrive at trailer 45 minutes prior to step-off
- Verify all sandbags loaded on carts/props
- Review assigned yard marker & roll direction
- Lock backdrop caster brakes in UNLOCKED position

On Field & Post-Show:

- Push cart directly to yard mark on judge's signal
- Lock all wheel brakes immediately upon arrival
- **Exit turf before 2:45** (behind front/back line)
- NEVER step onto field during the performance
- **Continuous motion** through exit gate to trailer lot!

Pine Creek High School Marching Band • Field Operations Crew

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